Old Sturgeon



Secrets of Knapp Street

A Local Myth and Hidden Puzzle

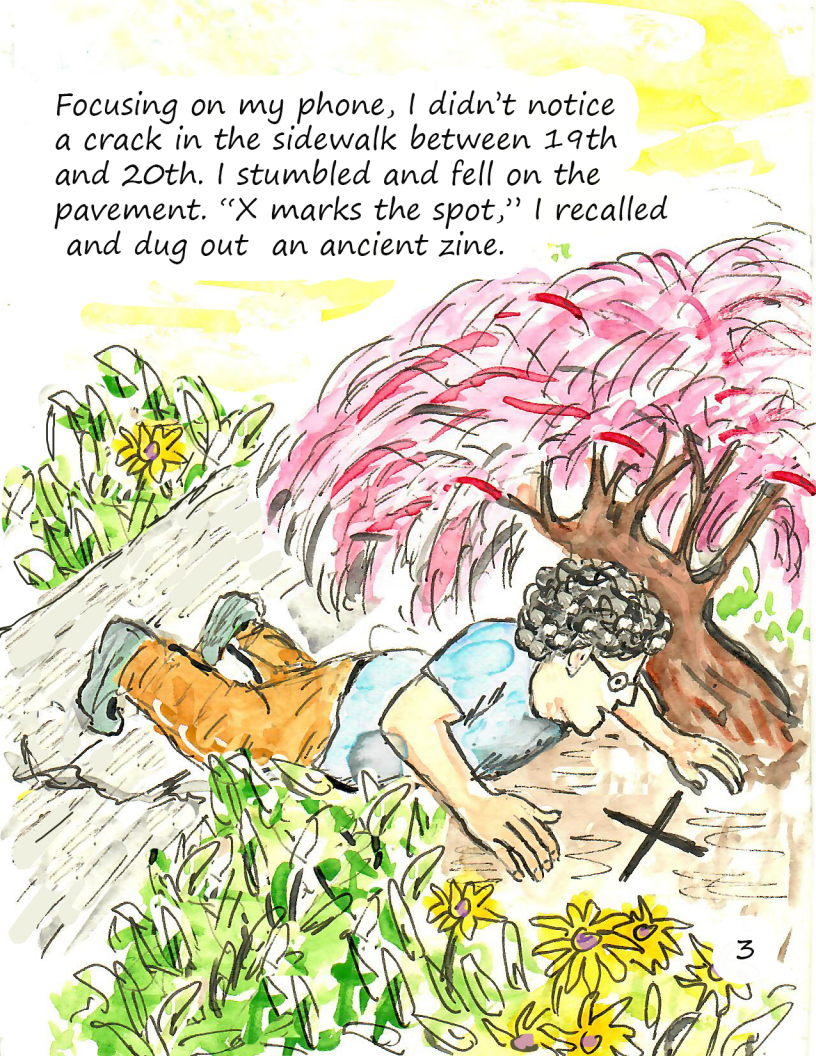
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As an avid Southeast Portland walker, I have long been troubled about Knapp Street: you follow it for a few blocks, say from 17th to 22nd, and lose it, only to find it again in Eastmoreland, watch it vanish in Woodstock and resurface in Clackamas. What happens in the Knappless lots? Where is Knapp when I can't see it?

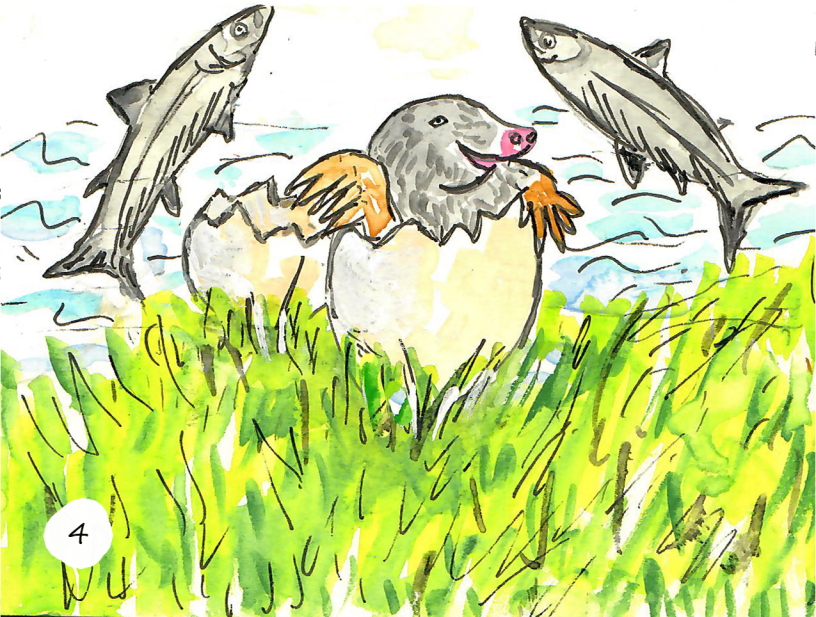
I asked my phone and it said that Knapp means "miner" in German and "hilltop" in English, which might explain why Knapp wanted to reach the top of the hill sometimes but in other times preferred to stay deep underground. The phone also told me who Richard and Minnie Knapp were. Do you know their story, or the one about that genius and Portland's forgotten hero, Isaac Smith?



Focusing on my phone, I didn't notice a crack in the sidewalk between 19th and 20th. I stumbled and fell on the pavement. "X marks the spot," I recalled and dug out an ancient zine.



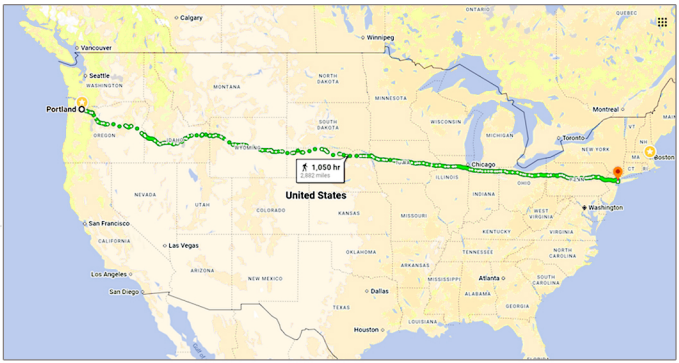
"In the beginning, the Willamette River spawned two salmon, Richard and Minnie. They swam into the Oaks Bottom Pond, where Minnie laid a golden egg.
From the egg came Knapp, a mole who tunneled up the hill eastward until he saw the light where 13th meets Sellwood Blvd. Knapp took a deep breath of September pollen and said, "I name thee Sellwood-Moleland, for here the mole came out of the land!"



"He rolled down the other side of the hill till he came to a halt at the bank of Crystal Springs Creek.
Teeth clenching, Knapp dug his way beneath the creek, the wetlands, the highway, the train tracks, and the golf course. The urge to go up caught him at SE 27th.
"I know what I want!" the mole exclaimed as the wind brushed the willow trees.
"I will walk across the continent, always in the open air, and wherever my feet touch the asphalt will be named Knapp."



"Alas, like Persephone, Knapp could not stay away from the underworld for long, and on 63rd he burrowed back into the soil.
He kept going—Richard and Minnie always in his heart—through the Inland Northwest, the Great Plains, Michigan, Connecticut, and New York.
In Brooklyn, he heard a voice from the ocean beyond Lew Fidler Park.
"Knappy, you made it!" It was Minnie.
"Mother," Knapp cried in relief, and dug his last tunnel, into the Atlantic.



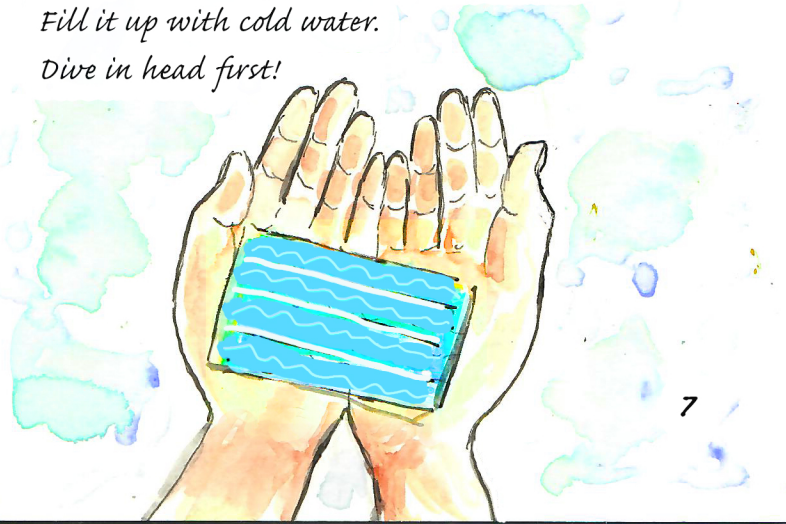
"To this day, you can see where Knapp walked, as all those places are named after him. Had he stayed above ground, I might be living in Sellwood-Moleland."
When Knapp Street "ends," I know, having read the long lost zine, it only pauses, and will come back when the time is right.
BTW, on the bottom of the ancient box where I found the zine I found this strange little poem.

Morning Face Wash or Mustering Courage

Make a swimming pool with your hands.

Fill it up with cold water.

Dive in head first!



Scan the QR code and send us an email with your favorite spot on Knapp St. We respond to every message.

Hidden Puzzle: Put together all the orange-brown letters. What do you get? How does that connect with Knapp and Isaac Smith?

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